

Job Hunt — Michael Kushman

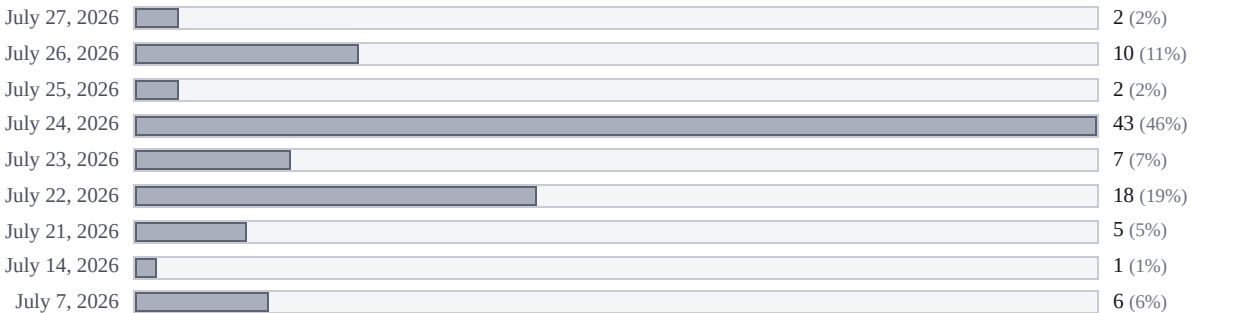
Verified application ledger · Gmail and Drive reconciled · simple tracker linked from the website

Updated July 27, 2026 — 94 verified applications · Sailor Health and Dench.com confirmed · Rillet and AIRE passed · first human reply of the campaign (Sage Recruiting)

94	39	1	1	3	5	4
APPLICATIONS IN	ATS CONFIRMATIONS	HUMAN REPLIES	LIVE CONVERSATIONS	REJECTIONS	IN PIPELINE	BACKLOG

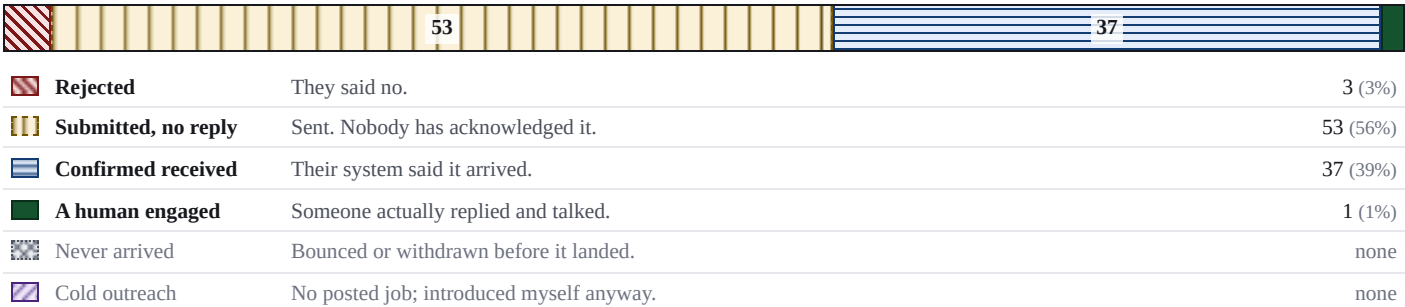
How many went out, by day

94 verified applications across 9 active days. Bars are to scale against the busiest day.



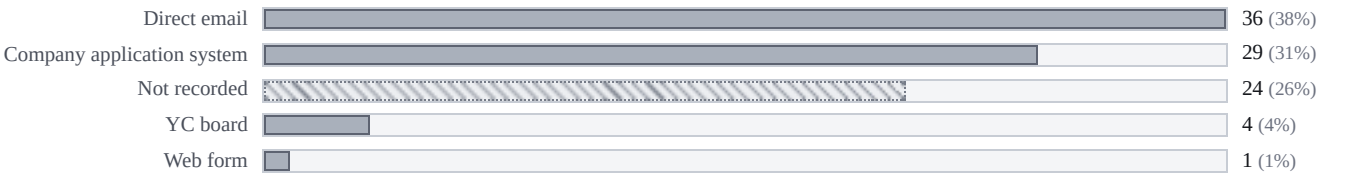
Where all 94 stand today

Every status carries its own label, count and fill pattern — the chart is readable in black and white, and colour is never the only cue.



How the applications were sent

Read from the notes column. “Not recorded” means the note does not say how it went out — it is shown, not hidden, because it is a real share of the ledger.



Why the confirmation numbers differ

The scoreboard says 39 ATS confirmations, but only 37 rows below currently read “Confirmed received.” Both are correct. 39 is *cumulative* — every confirmation ever received. The ledger shows *current state*, and 2 of those confirmations (Rillet and Tsenta) were superseded by a later outcome, so those rows now show that outcome instead. Nothing was lost and nothing was double-counted.

What counts: Submitted applications and delivered live-role emails count; drafts, bounces, opened forms, research, speculative outreach, and duplicate resends do not.
Standing rules: Deduplicate by company, role, and earliest submission date. Resends update the existing row; distinct roles at the same company remain separate.

The full ledger

All 94 verified applications, newest day first. Each entry carries its status in words, plus the channel it went out through.

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
JULY 27, 2026 — 2 VERIFIED					
Dench.com YC BOARD Applied via Work at a Startup (YC) · confirmation 7/27	Founding Engineer	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/27
Sailor Health COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby confirmation 7/27	Founding Engineer	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/27
JULY 26, 2026 — 10 VERIFIED					
Aurorin CAD COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Applied via Polymer · successful submission confirmed · ycombinator.com	Founding Engineer	\$120–160K + 3–4%	San Francisco, CA	 Confirmed received	7/26
Awell Health DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@awellhealth.com · corrected resend added résumé · counted once · awellhealth.com	Product Engineer	\$100–180K + eq	Remote · US-time-zone hours	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
Eagle DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to tom@eagleeng.com · résumé attached · jobs.ashbyhq.com	Design Engineer	\$150–300K + eq	NYC · on-site	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
Guac DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jack@guac-ai.com · résumé attached · ycombinator.com	Fullstack Engineer	\$150–250K + 0.5–1%	NYC · on-site 5d/wk	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
InstaLILY AI COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse confirmation received · moved from backlog · job-boards.greenhouse.io	Design Engineer	\$100–120K + eq	NYC	 Confirmed received	7/26
Outmarket DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@outmarket.ai · delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · outmarket.ai	Front-End AI Engineer	Competitive + eq	Remote · US or India	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
PrairieLearn COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby confirmation received · jobs.ashbyhq.com	Full-Stack Software Engineer	\$100–180K + eq	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/26
Profound DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to dylan@tryprofound.com · résumé attached · tryprofound.com	Design Engineer	\$120–250K	NYC / Buenos Aires · on-site	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
ProxyBase DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jobs@proxybase.xyz · role-specific pitch delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · proxybase.xyz	Full-Stack Developer	\$100–160K + eq	Remote global	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
Sylience (Chord) DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@sylience.com · delivered; Gmail metadata shows no attachment · sylience.com	Founding Engineer	\$100–150K + 1–5%	Remote · US time zones	 Submitted, no reply	7/26
JULY 25, 2026 — 2 VERIFIED					
Counterpart COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse confirmation received · job-boards.greenhouse.io	Product Engineer	\$110K+ est.	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/25
elly COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse receipt proves submission but omits title · role deliberately not inferred · job-boards.greenhouse.io	Role not stated (Greenhouse confirmation)	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/25

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
JULY 24, 2026 — 43 VERIFIED					
AIRE	Founding Engineer	\$100–250K + eq	Remote US/Canada · NYC preferred	 Rejected	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Passed 7/27 — Ashley at Sage Recruiting replied by hand; not a fit for the current role, keeping him on their hotlist for future openings · FIRST human reply of the campaign · cold email to recruitment@aire.xyz 7/24 · aire.xyz					
Arterial	Junior Full-Stack Engineer	—	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/24
NOT RECORDED Application receipt confirmed materials and role · arterial.us					
Atria Health	Staff Software Engineer, Agentic AI	\$230–290K	NYC hybrid · Tue–Thu	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to talent@atria.org delivered · auto-reply directed candidates to site · apply.workable.com					
Avery	Software Engineer	—	On-site / Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to info@averyiq.com · delivered; no bounce · averyiq.com					
Catalyst Wayfare	AI Engineer / Agent Builder	—	Remote US · Eastern overlap	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to talent@cwai.co · delivered; no bounce · catalystwayfare.ai					
Colonist	Product Engineer	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM colonist.io · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Cora AI	Founding Full Stack / Applied AI Engineer	\$190–250K + eq	Remote US / SF	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@cora.ai · moved from backlog · cora.ai					
DearHiringManager.io	Full-Stack Developer	\$120–160K	Remote · US/EU time zones	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to lars@dearhiringmanager.io · delivered; no bounce · dearhiringmanager.io					
Deployment.io	Forward Deployed Engineer	Competitive + eq	Remote US or India	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jobs@deployment.io 7/24 · resent 7/26 · counted once · deployment.io					
DwellSafe	Full-Stack Engineer	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@dwellsafe.ai · delivered; no bounce · dwellsafe.ai					
Emergences	AI / Systems Engineer	\$120–150K + eq	Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to jack@emergences.ai · delivered; no bounce · emergences.ai					
Ephanti	Founding Engineer, Agentic AI	—	Remote US/EU	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@ephanti.com · delivered; no bounce · ephanti.com					
FanShares	Founding Engineer	\$150–200K + eq	United States	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to leon@fansharesapp.com · delivered; no bounce · fansharesapp.com					
Hermes Web	Founding Engineer	—	Remote worldwide	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Open Core Ventures · Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 (as Open Core Ventures) · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
Hightouch	Role not stated (Greenhouse confirmation)	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 · receipt omitted the role title; deliberately not inferred · hightouch.com					
Hotwash	Founding Engineer	—	Remote US · Boston a plus	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to hiring@hotwash.com · delivered; no bounce · hotwash.com					
JustiGuide	Frontend Engineer	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to careers@justiguide.com · delivered; no bounce · justiguide.com					

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Kadoa	Senior Software Engineer	—	Fully remote	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to adrian@kadoa.com · delivered; no bounce · kadoa.com				
Kanary	Full Stack Engineer	—	Remote US · Seattle hub	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to steven@kanary.com · delivered; no bounce · kanary.com				
Kyra	Senior/Staff Product Engineer	—	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to n@kyra.health · delivered; no bounce · engineers.kyra.health				
Lantern	Junior Software Engineer	—	Manhattan · 4d/wk	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to maksym@withlantern.com 7/24 · resent 7/26 · counted once · careers.moxxie.vc				
LightSight	Forward Deployed Software Engineer	—	Remote US · travel	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to contact@lightsight.ai · delivered; no bounce · lightsight.ai				
Lumen Energy	Product Engineer	—	Remote	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Solar/battery climatetech · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com				
Mastra	Product Engineer	—	Remote worldwide	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	TypeScript agent framework · Ashby confirmation 7/24 — if fit, recruiter call is next step · jobs.ashbyhq.com				
Mavenly	Founding Engineer, Full-Stack	\$170–210K + 0.75–1.5%	Atlanta / Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@mavenly.ai · delivered; no bounce · mavenly.ai				
Onboarded	Product Engineer, full-stack	—	Global remote	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Applied via Lever · Lever confirmation 7/24 · jobs.lever.co				
Ondo Finance	Full-Stack Software Engineer	Competitive	Remote US	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Greenhouse confirmation received · job-boards.greenhouse.io				
OnePay	Design Engineer	\$130–160K	Fully remote	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	React Native · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com				
Ontix	Technical Product Manager	—	Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to l33t@ontix.io · delivered; no bounce · ontix.io				
OpenEd	Product Engineer	—	—	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	⚠️ Backers still unverified — sanity-check before investing more · Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com				
Pax Historia	Founding Engineer (Full Stack Web)	\$150–215K + 0.25–1%	San Francisco · in-person	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers@paxhistoria.co · delivered; no bounce · ycombinator.com				
Puma Browser	AI/ML Engineer	—	Remote-first	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to careers+ai@pumabrowser.com · delivered; no bounce · puma.tech				
Resend	Product Engineer	\$151–170K	Fully remote	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Ashby confirmation 7/24 — "a real human will review" · resend.com				
Riot IQ	AI-native Software Engineer	—	Seattle / Remote US	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to robertneir@riotiq.com · delivered; no bounce · riotiq.com				
SalvoHealth	Software Engineer	\$100–160K	NYC / Remote US	✅ Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Lever confirmation received · jobs.lever.co				
SecureFlow	Junior Software Engineer	\$80–110K + 0.1–0.3%	Remote global	📧 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL	Direct email to Josepbbob@proton.me · delivered; no bounce · secureflow.tech				

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Span	Product Engineer	\$100–200K + eq	Fully remote	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby confirmation 7/24 · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Teckfinty	AI / Agent Engineer	—	Remote	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to recruitment@teckfinty.com · delivered; no bounce · teckfinty.com					
TrueBuilt	Founding Engineer	—	Remote-first	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
NOT RECORDED Pre-construction platform · no confirmation email yet · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
Vertex	AI Product Engineer	\$101–136K	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Was in backlog — applied via Workday · mention HN to Paul Chung if contacted · Workday confirmation 7/24 · vertexinc.wd1.myworkdayjobs.com					
Wheelhouse	Full Stack Engineer	—	Remote-first	 Confirmed received	7/24
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM React/Next/TS + dataviz · Greenhouse confirmation 7/24 · job-boards.greenhouse.io					
Wildflower Health	Junior Software Engineer	—	Remote US	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to chris.reath@wildflowerhealth.com · delivered; exact role now archived · wildflowerhealth.com					
Yuzu	Product Engineer	\$140–265K + eq	NYC · 5d/wk	 Submitted, no reply	7/24
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to kev@yuzu.health; OOO redirected to ryan@yuzu.health · counted once · yuzu.health					
JULY 23, 2026 — 7 VERIFIED					
AgentPress	Full-Stack AI Engineer	—	Remote US/Canada	 Confirmed received	7/23
DIRECT EMAIL Direct email to apply@agent.press · automated receipt used legacy Emerge Haus branding · agent.press					
Airtable	Design Technologist	\$224–317.2K	NYC / SF hybrid 2–3d/wk	 Confirmed received	7/23
NOT RECORDED Restored 7/24 audit — confirmation from jobs@airtable.com 7/23 · AI-assisted workflow answers · Worldbook as latest AI experiment · airtable.com					
Aqua Voice	Design Engineer	\$130–210K + eq/bonus	NYC / SF on-site	 Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 (received twice) · six solo products + ThreadKeep pitch · aquavoice.com					
Ashby	Junior Design Engineer, Americas	\$122–220K + eq	Remote US	 Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Was in backlog — applied 7/23 · Ashby confirmation received (found in Gmail) · ashbyhq.com					
Gumloop	Design Engineer	—	NYC / SF / Vancouver on-site	 Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 · agent-legibility pitch · confirmed NYC office availability · gumloop.com					
Pace	Design Engineer (first design hire)	Competitive + early eq	NYC on-site	 Confirmed received	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Restored 7/24 audit — Ashby confirmation 7/23 · first Design Engineer · WPCNA maps 1:1 · \$46M Series B insurance AI · jobs.ashbyhq.com					
Rillet	Design Engineer	\$150–240K	NYC / SF hybrid	 Rejected	7/23
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby rejection 7/27 — “moving forward with other candidates,” invited to reapply as new roles open · Ashby confirmation 7/23 · full arc concept → shipped · AI-native design-to-code · rillet.com					
JULY 22, 2026 — 18 VERIFIED					
Credal.ai	Founding Design Engineer	\$170–230K + eq	Brooklyn, on-site	 Confirmed received	7/22
DIRECT EMAIL Follow-up emailed to Ravin (CEO) · credal.ai					
Dimely	Founding Engineer, Full Stack	\$100–140K + 1–3%	Remote / Hybrid SF	 Confirmed received	7/22
YC BOARD Dover confirmation — the “lost form” actually went through · YC S24, 4th hire · usedimely.com					

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
Fifth Door	Front End Engineer — games + AI	— + eq	Remote US 🐶	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Daniel · Ad Arma maps 1:1 — strongest-fit pitch of the run · fifthdoor.com				
Finta	Founding Designer (employee #3)	\$140–220K + 1–5%	SF / Remote 🐶	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Andy · designs-in-code pitch · portfolio-review interview · finta.com				
Git AI	Founding Engineer	\$190–220K + eq	NYC in-person	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Pitch sent direct to founder (Aidan) · alternate Gmail draft is dead — delete · usegitai.com				
Hera	Founding Product Designer	€80–130K + eq	Berlin pref / NY remote	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Peter (CEO) · "slope not intercept" · hera.video				
Humwork	Founding Engineer	\$120–150K + 2.5–10%	SF in-person	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Email to founders@ (their preferred channel) · they reply within 48h — watch inbox · humwork.ai				
Infisical	Developer Advocate	\$120–190K	Remote US/CA	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Tony · teaching/translation pitch · 7/24: they viewed Mike's LinkedIn — worth a look at their other openings · infisical.com				
Infisical	Design Engineer, Brand	\$100–180K	Remote US/CA	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Double-apply flagged as intentional · infisical.com				
Nixo	Founding Member of Technical Staff	\$150–250K + eq	Remote US	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Priya · WPCNA deployment-mess story · ycombinator.com				
Novig	AI Automation Engineer	\$200–230K	NYC	✅ Confirmed received	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Gambling domain — ignore any reply · novig.com				
Onlook	Founding Engineer — "Cursor for Designers"	\$130–200K + eq	Remote US 🐶	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Daniel · "the user Onlook exists for" pitch · onlook.com				
Pillar	Founding Designer	—	Remote US 🐶	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Creator-economy suite · "I was your user for 20 years" · ycombinator.com				
ProhostAI	Founding Engineer, Full Stack	\$100–180K + eq	Remote US	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
NOT RECORDED	Bill · Airbnb/Dropbox founders · honest-gap pitch · prohost.ai				
Rivet	Full Stack Engineer (early team)	Not posted — quoted \$110–140K	Remote US 🐶	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
WEB FORM	Google Form recorded · AI direct-to-fan platform for artists · favorite band: Tool · rivet.app				
Scott AI	Design Engineer	\$140–250K + 0.5–1.5%	NYC / SF office	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
YC BOARD	YC F25 · planning layer for coding-agent teams · Metro-North commutable · tryscott.ai				
The Company Company	Founding Design Engineer	\$130–200K + eq	Remote US	📄 Submitted, no reply	7/22
YC BOARD	Julius · 1-person YC P26 · watch WaaS inbox · workatastartup.com				
Tsenta	Founding Engineer	—	Remote US	🟢 A human engaged	7/22
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Applied via Ashby · live conversation — the only human contact so far · tsenta.com				

JULY 21, 2026 — 5 VERIFIED

Anthropic	Design Engineer, Web	\$260–305K	Remote, 25% office	✅ Confirmed received	7/21
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM	Greenhouse confirmation · timeline is Feb 2026 — never say two years · anthropic.com				

COMPANY	ROLE	COMPENSATION	LOCATION	STATUS	DATE
GitHub	Design Engineer III (Req 5478)	\$153.9–285.9K	Remote	 Rejected	7/21
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM iCIMS rejection 7/23 — reviewed by a Talent Partner, "moving forward with other candidates" · first decision of the campaign · github.com					
Luma AI	Forward Deployed Creative [US]	\$150–200K	NY / LA / PA office	 Confirmed received	7/21
NOT RECORDED Gem confirmation received · lumalabs.ai					
OpenAI	Model Designer, Core Models	\$266–295K + eq	SF hybrid 3d/wk	 Confirmed received	7/21
NOT RECORDED Their system parsed first name as "White" (autofill glitch) — correct casually if contacted · openai.com					
Runway	Design Engineer, Runway Labs	\$250–310K	Remote	 Confirmed received	7/21
COMPANY APPLICATION SYSTEM Ashby confirmation · earlier 7/7 email to recruiting@ = same application · runwayml.com					
JULY 14, 2026 — 1 VERIFIED					
Hugging Face	Wild Card application	—	Remote	 Confirmed received	7/14
NOT RECORDED The one that started the campaign · Workable confirmation · fresh anchor application queued · huggingface.co					
JULY 7, 2026 — 6 VERIFIED					
Arize	Open Source Design Engineer	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
NOT RECORDED No reply · arize.com					
Collier.Simon	Creative Technologist	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
NOT RECORDED One thread (original + 2 corrections) · no reply · colliersimon.com					
Felt	Spatial tools / creative technologist	—	—	 Confirmed received	7/7
NOT RECORDED "Application received" auto-ack · felt.com					
Lightning Labs	AI Product Engineer	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
NOT RECORDED No reply · lightning.engineering					
Scenario	Creative Technologist	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
NOT RECORDED Canned ack only (29s after send) · scenario.com					
USB Club / garden3d	Part-time Design Engineer	—	—	 Submitted, no reply	7/7
NOT RECORDED Sent to Hugh · no reply · garden3d.net					

Appendix — plain-language glossary

Extracted from the live tracker so the paper and the website always say the same thing.

HOW AN APPLICATION TRAVELS

ATS *also: applicant tracking system, applicant tracking systems*

The software a company uses to collect and sort applications. Ashby, Greenhouse, Lever, Workday and iCIMS are the ones that turn up most often on this page.

ATS confirmation *also: automated confirmation, confirmation email, application confirmation, application receipt*

The automatic email their system sends the moment an application lands. It proves the file arrived; it does not mean a person has opened it.

portal *also: portals, candidate portal, application portal*

A company's own web page where you type in your history and upload a résumé instead of emailing anyone. Most of them make you retype everything that is already on the résumé you just attached.

req *also: reqs, requisition, requisitions, job requisition*

The internal ticket saying a company has the budget to pay one more person, usually with a number attached. No req, no job — even if the posting is still up.

autoresponder *also: auto-reply, autoreply, auto-ack, canned ack, automated receipt, automatic reply*

A pre-written reply that fires the second your message arrives, sometimes within seconds. It tells you the machine is working, and nothing about your chances.

no-reply *also: noreply, no-reply address, do-not-reply, donotreply*

An address that can send mail but cannot receive it, so answering it goes nowhere. To reach an actual person you have to find their real address yourself.

bounced *also: bounce, bounces, bounced back, hard bounce*

The message never reached anyone — the address was wrong or dead and the mail system sent it back. Notes here that say “no bounce” mean the opposite: it arrived.

cold email *also: cold emails, cold outreach, cold emailed, cold-emailed*

Writing straight to someone at a company that never posted the job you want. It is not rude, and at small companies it is often how hiring actually starts.

referral *also: referrals, referred, internal referral*

Someone inside the company passes your name along, which lifts you out of the pile and in front of a human. It is the biggest single advantage in hiring, and the main reason two people with the same experience get very different results.

WHO YOU ARE TALKING TO

recruiter *also: recruiters, in-house recruiter*

The person whose job is to find candidates and move them through the steps. They are not the one who decides, and they are usually juggling dozens of openings at once.

Talent Partner *also: talent partners, talent acquisition partner, talent acquisition*

A recruiter with a warmer job title. Same work: finding people, booking calls, and sending the yes or the no.

agency *also: agencies, recruiting agency, staffing agency, agency recruiter, external recruiter*

An outside firm that finds candidates for other companies and is paid only when someone is hired. They can be genuinely helpful, but the company is the one paying them, not you.

hiring manager *also: hiring managers*

The person you would actually work for, and the one who decides. Everyone before them is a filter.

hotlist *also: hot list, talent pool, talent community*

A list of people a company says it will remember when something opens up. Saying it costs them nothing, and almost nobody is ever contacted from one.

STAGES

Submitted *also: submitted, no reply*

Sent, and nothing has come back — no receipt, no rejection, not a word. This is where most rows on this page sit.

Submitted ✓ *also: confirmed received*

Their system sent back a receipt, so the application is known to have arrived. The mark shows where a row stands today, so two applications that later turned into a rejection or a conversation no longer carry it.

screen *also: phone screen, recruiter screen, screening call, initial screen*

A short first call, usually twenty or thirty minutes with a recruiter, to check the basics. It is a gate, not really an interview.

take-home *also: take home, take-home assignment, take-home project, take home test*

A piece of real work you do alone, on your own time, unpaid, and send back. Reasonable ones take an evening; unreasonable ones eat a weekend.

loop *also: interview loop, onsite loop, final loop, onsite interviews*

The final round: several interviews back to back, often in one day, with different people. Afterwards they compare notes and decide together.

Conversation *also: live conversation, live conversations, conversations*

A real person wrote back and a genuine back-and-forth started. It is the rarest status on this page.

Rejected *also: rejection, rejections, declined, passed on*

They said no. Sometimes it arrives as a form letter, occasionally as a real note from a real person.

in pipeline *also: pipeline, in the pipeline*

Applications still alive in some form — sent, confirmed, or being talked about — with no final answer yet. Silence keeps a row here until it is plainly dead.

backlog *also: in backlog, moved from backlog*

Jobs worth applying to that have not gone out yet. Keeping them separate is what stops good intentions from being counted as work done.

MONEY AND OWNERSHIP

base *also: base salary, base pay*

The cash salary, before anything else is added on. It is the only part you can actually count on.

equity *also: eq, equity grant, ownership stake*

A slice of ownership in the company, handed over instead of some of the cash. It is worth nothing unless the company is later sold or goes public.

options *also: stock options, share options, option grant*

The right to buy company shares later at a price fixed today. If the company grows you buy cheap; if it does not, you simply never buy.

vesting *also: vest, vests, vested, vesting schedule*

You earn your equity gradually, month by month, rather than receiving it on day one. Leave early and you keep only the part you have earned so far.

cliff *also: one-year cliff, 1-year cliff, vesting cliff*

A waiting period, usually a full year, before any equity is yours at all. Leave a day before it and you walk away with none of it.

OTE *also: on-target earnings, on target earnings*

Salary plus the bonus you would earn if you hit every target. Read it as the best case, not as the offer.

comp *also: compensation, total comp, comp package, total compensation*

Everything you are paid — salary, bonus, equity and benefits — added into one number. Companies quote the big total; the cash part is the part that pays rent.

WHERE WORK HAPPENS

Remote *also: remote US, fully remote, remote-first, remote global, remote worldwide, work from home*

You work from where you live. Read the fine print — remote usually still means a particular country, and often specific hours overlapping someone else's day.

Hybrid *also: hybrid schedule, part remote*

Some days in the office, the rest at home, with the split set by the company rather than by you. Listings here spell it out, like three days a week.

On-site *also: onsite, in-person, in person, in the office*

You are expected in the building, most days or every day. For these jobs that usually means living near New York or San Francisco.

ROLE TITLES

Design Engineer *also: design engineers, design technologist, creative technologist*

Someone who designs how a thing looks and behaves, then writes the code that makes it real. Some companies call the same job design technologist or creative technologist.

Founding Engineer *also: founding engineers, founding design engineer, founding designer, founding member of technical staff, member of technical staff*

One of the first few people building the product, before there are teams, managers or process. More ownership and more equity, with no guarantee the company lasts.

Product Engineer *also: product engineers*

An engineer trusted to decide what to build, not only how to build it, working close to the people who use it. The opposite of being handed a finished spec.

Full-Stack *also: full stack, fullstack, full-stack engineer, full stack engineer, full-stack developer*

Able to work on the part people see and the machinery behind it. At a small company it usually just means everything.

STARTUP VOCABULARY

YC *also: Y Combinator, YCombinator*

Y Combinator, the best known startup program: it gives brand-new companies a little money and three months of coaching in exchange for a piece of them. Tags like S24 or F25 say which batch a company came through.

WaaS *also: Work at a Startup*

Work at a Startup, Y Combinator's own job board for the companies it has funded. A few of the applications here went out through it.

accelerator *also: accelerators, startup accelerator, incubator*

A short program that funds a group of new companies, coaches them, and ends with them pitching investors. Y Combinator is the famous one.

Ashby

One of the systems companies use to take in applications, common at startups. Its automatic receipt is what puts the check mark on many rows here.

Greenhouse

Another widely used application system, more common at bigger companies. Its receipt sometimes leaves the job title out, which is why a couple of rows here say the role was not stated.

iCIMS

An older application system, used mostly by large established employers. It produced the first rejection of this campaign.

Polymer

A smaller, newer application system used by one company on this list. Same purpose as the rest: take applications in and sort them.

WHAT THE POLITE PHRASES ACTUALLY MEAN

moving forward with other candidates *also: move forward with other candidates, moving forward with others, decided to move forward with other candidates, pursuing other candidates*

This is a no. It is the standard phrasing for a rejection, and it does not mean a decision is still open.

not a great fit *also: not a fit, not a good fit, not the right fit, not quite the right fit, not a fit for the current role*

Also a no, usually a kind one. It rarely means anything specific about you, and asking what was missing almost never gets an answer.

keep you on our hotlist *also: keeping him on their hotlist, keeping you on our hotlist, on our hotlist, keep you on file, keep your resume on file, keep your résumé on file*

A gentle way to end things without saying never. It costs nothing to say and rarely leads anywhere, so treat it as a no with the door left ajar.

we'll be in touch *also: we'll be in touch, we will be in touch, we'll be in touch soon, be in touch*

On its own, this means nothing. With a date or a named next step attached it is real; without one, expect silence.

reach out *also: reach back out, reaching out, we'll reach out, we'll reach out*

Office language for “get in touch”. When they say they will reach out, no promise has been made; when you do it yourself, it is the part of a job hunt that actually works.

circle back *also: circling back, circle back with you, come back to you*

To return to something later. In hiring it nearly always means no decision is being made today, and often none is ever made.